



Audit of Existing Conditions

Chapter 1

SIGNS	2
<i>Messages, placement and maintenance</i>	
TRAILS	6
<i>Surface inconsistency, feature locators, vegetation, trash, erosion, repair, graffiti and other hazards</i>	
STEWARDSHIP	10
<i>User groups, perimeter conditions, territorial reinforcement and neighborhood buy-in</i>	
EMERGENCY RESPONSE CAPABILITIES	13
<i>Response items, cooperation among agencies and public education</i>	
APPENDIX	24
<i>Crisis/Emergency Management Terminology</i>	



1.0 Audit of Existing Conditions

SIGN MESSAGES

Sign messages are critical to the proper functioning of the trail. For example, signs can carry warnings about dangerous conditions or indicate how to report problems. Yet most of the current trail signage is too general to perform these functions, or the warning messages are so overused that they may be ignored.

Emergency responders can be aided through the use of signs that help locate the victim(s) for the purpose of rescue; currently there are no such signs. These messages should indicate to victims or witnesses where they are and whom and how to call for help. Additionally they should identify the nearest vehicular access point to the land trail or the nearest landing for a river rescue.

Of the current messages presented, many are underscaled and can't be interpreted in the appropriate length of time. For example, the message on the buoy in photo 1 is too small to be read from a distance and the speed of the water would not likely allow for someone to leisurely approach and read its message.

This can place users of the river in jeopardy. Message length should also be taken into consideration whenever viewers are in motion (e.g. boating down the river or biking the land trail (photo 2)).



1

Some messages are also illegible because the signs have deteriorated.

There are not coordinated colors or shapes for messages along the trail. (for example, using fluorescent green triangular mile markers or fluorescent orange octagonal caution/warning signs). Such color schemes allow users to more quickly and easily interpret presented messages.

There is no continuity of message(s) along the trail system. It has not been resolved by interested and responsible parties what types of messages should be displayed based on what purposes the signs serve (e.g. educational, location information, directional, etc.)



2



1.0 Audit of Existing Conditions

Cell phone coverage indicator signs are not currently along the trail system. There was a reluctance to utilize such signage because the capability might not always be present.

River users may not carry cell phones on the water but land trail users usually do; they are frequently used to report incidents on the river/trail. There was no signage to indicate where to report an incident.

Other phone and communication resources are also not advertised along the trail. Fire and police stations offer ready communications opportunities, as do stores and public phones.

SIGN PLACEMENT

Sign placement considers who will be in a position to read or observe the sign, how the sign will appear under certain conditions (flood, tree growth, parked vehicles) and how the sign will fit in or stand out from the surroundings.



In the case of a “semi-natural” trail system the signs should reflect sensitivity for the setting. In some areas the current signage detracted from the natural environment, both because of its quantity and its poor condition. Many users might be more dismayed at the “sign pollution” (photos 3 & 4) than interested in the messages. These photos were taken at the Phoenixville PA Fish and Boat Commission Access, above Black Rock Dam.

Warning signs must be located well before the physical features to which they pertain. For example, the only warning signs for the dams were in such close proximity to the dams that they provided insufficient notice to boaters. A sign warning “NO BOATING” that is mounted on the dam is not appropriate as a warning of impending danger. (Note that, according to local authorities vandalism to signs at Black Rock Dam is a major problem; apparently warning signs for the dam had been removed or defaced).





1.0 Audit of Existing Conditions

As pictured in photo 1, a short distance upriver from the dams are floating markers that comply with PA Fisheries and Boating Commission and Dams of Death laws; however, the bouys may be of little help to novice river users who often have not taken boater safety courses. The river was quite high at the time of the survey and anyone in the river would likely have been in trouble by the time they could read the floating signage.

Sign placement also needs to consider the immediate physical features; currently there are signs obscured by trees or buried in vegetation. River hazard warning signs buried in the woods may contribute to serious liability issues in the case of injury or death. Other hidden signs may encourage extremely risky behavior (photo 5).

SIGN MAINTENANCE

Sign maintenance is extremely important to maximize exposure to the posted message and minimize the likelihood that decay will obliterate the message and lead to injury or crime. The tour of the trail found numerous examples of damaged, decayed, outdated and graffiti-covered signs.

Damaged signs expose passersby to sharp edges. The post on the pictured sign below was broken at the ground. The sign and post can be used as a weapon. That the sign is on private property at the edge of the park at the Linfield Dam does not diminish the related risks.





1.0 Audit of Existing Conditions

If signs are damaged or decayed, they look bad in the park environment. It is a long recognized principle that decay precedes crime (Jacobs – 1961, Wilson – 1982, Bratton - 1994). When any element looks poorly maintained it is likely to lead to a disregard of the signage and an increased likelihood for crime.

Sign pollution is also part of the “decay” mentioned above. Much of this falls under the ***Broken Window Theory*** which states that uncared-for property becomes the property of the unintended user and will result in unintended behaviors. Take for example the movie *It's a Wonderful Life*, where one of the main characters picks up a rock, makes a wish, and throws it through a window that is among the many that are already broken. His action was, in his mind, justified because there were already other broken windows. He felt comfortable with his inappropriate action. Then when it came time for the other character to throw a rock and make a wish she did so without hesitation. One inappropriate action reinforces acceptance for the next.

INSUFFICIENT SIGNAGE

There is an overall lack of signage to indicate trailheads, hazards and conflict(s) involving uses, features and materials. Trail users clearly need more guidance and information than what was observed.

Upriver bridge abutments displayed few signs, if any. One exception was the Route 82 bridge in Birdsboro (photo 7). A “KEEP RIGHT” sign was added to the bridge supports to warn boaters to the right to avoid dangerous hydraulics on the left.

It may very well be that a lack of appropriate signage has contributed to several preventable deaths over the years that the dams have been in place. This issue is a serious matter of liability in our increasingly litigious society.



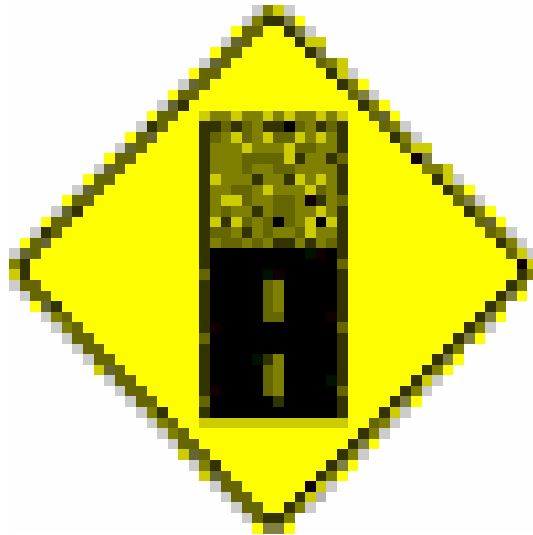


1.0 Audit of Existing Conditions

TRAILS

SURFACE INCONSISTENCY

There are no signs warning of surface inconsistency or general surface conditions. Paving may lead to gravel which may lead to dirt path. Someone on a bicycle or with limited mobility could find himself or herself in a difficult position. Those who find paving the most appropriate surface on which to ride or land would likely need some warning that surfaces are about to change. The nature of the trail surface is important even where transition is not a problem.



FEATURE LOCATORS

The locations of water trail landings are not well marked from the parks, land trails or river. In Port Clinton's parks the current landing is only about 25 feet from the more appropriate landing. Signage will contribute to the use of the more appropriate landing.

There were no signs indicating the nature, location and uses of trail features. Consistent use of "NO" signs can be discouraging and result in general disregard of the sign messages. Signs that display only negative messages may not be appropriate.





1.0 Audit of Existing Conditions

TRAIL VEGETATION

Vegetation prevents effective surveillance (photo 9). Even though it is defoliated due to the onset of winter, vegetation is still thick along the trail edges and results in numerous hiding places from which inappropriate actions can take place. Trail-side debris bears out the observation that miscreants hide in the woods, drink, smoke and use drugs (needle found along with bottles). Though the trail is generally wide enough on the prepared surface it is not wide enough on the sides to facilitate observations by trail users.



TRAIL TRASH

Debris along the trail was common in some areas. Items found included a hypodermic needle, alcohol containers, general trash, and discarded machinery.

The observation platform in Bertolet (photo 10) is an appealing and attractive location that should draw visitors, but during the tour the odor of human fecal matter was noticeable. Nearby there was evidence of homelessness and vagrancy as well as gang activity. Mattresses, general trash and drug activity debris make this area feel very unsafe. If trail users feel this area is unpleasant or unsafe they will likely avoid the area, further surrendering it to the unintended users.

Other more “natural” debris can also pose problems. River debris, trees and log jams that form strainers, and general trash pose dangers to water trail users. Where these items accumulate around bridge abutments, dams and natural river features such as rocks create dangerous water hydraulics.





1.0 Audit of Existing Conditions

EROSION AND DETRITUS

Much erosion and detritus deposits have degraded dams and low-lying areas of the land trail due to the unusually heavy and frequent rains in 2003,

REPAIRS

Manufactured items need to be monitored and repaired periodically just as signs do. For example, at the Manayunk Bicycle Trail there is a broken fence on the river-view segment of trail, exposing users to the possibility of accidental falls through broken segments. Flat Rock Dam is visible in the fence picture (photo 11).

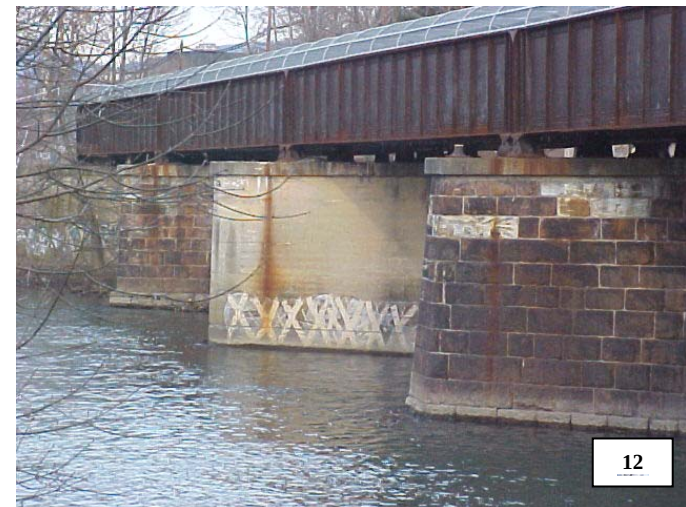


GRAFFITI

Gang graffiti and general tagging were found. Some of the graffiti shows a lack of concern for personal safety on the part of the vandal.

Most of the graffiti is "tagging." Tagging is not generally gang related and indicates a desire, by the tagger, to leave a mark in conspicuous locations. Unlike gang graffiti, tagging does not seek to claim space but rather identify the tagger. The more prolific and creative the marking or location the greater the reputation that is earned.

As in the general concept of "Broken Windows" tagging invites more tagging. However in photo 12 the tagging represents a conflict that may be dangerous; the crossed-out tagging indicates territorial conflict not usually found in tagging.





1.0 Audit of Existing Conditions

HAZARDS

Some perimeter hazards are also trail interior hazards. Dangerous trail road crossings exist for bicycles and pose unfortunately high risks. Pictured here, in photos 13 & 14, is a slope in the trail leading down to a roadway with signage that is inappropriate and not maintained. The warning sign on the pavement was worn away making it undecipherable. Additionally, warning signage to indicate an impending risk for drivers is placed so far down the road from the source of the conflict/risk so as to render it nearly useless.

As mentioned before, **the incorrect placement of signage indicating hazards adds another level of danger.** The sign asking drivers to share the road is placed after the area in which they are to come across bicyclists coming down the slope of the paved trail. It is not hard to imagine someone on a bicycle entering the roadway without looking over his or her right shoulder (a difficult maneuver on a bicycle) to look

for conflict or danger. The angled intersection is visible in the first picture in this section titled “Hazards.” The angle of entry for crossing roadways is a known concern for the SRGA, as demonstrated during the tour.





1.0 Audit of Existing Conditions

Pictured here, in photo 15, is a warning sign stating that no boating is allowed and that people should stay 200 feet back. The sign is in the woods on the bank of the river in alignment with the dam that was not visible under high water conditions. It would be a fair conclusion to make that the sign placement could contribute to serious injury or death. The liability seems extreme and avoidable.



STEWARDSHIP

TRAIL USERS

There are currently three user groups of the land and water. They are:

- **Intended users** – Pedestrians, cyclists, educational groups, bird watchers, trail manager representatives and maintenance personnel
- **Unintended users** – Gangs, vagrants, drug and alcohol users, 4-wheelers, etc.
- **Emergency personnel** – Police, fire, ambulance, water rescue, and hazardous materials personnel

All user groups should be considered in the signage process. Groups that frequent the trail system or have some responsibility for it should feel they will benefit from their “ownership” of the trail, resulting in good stewardship.

It is natural for people to take more interest in something they own. Designing an environment that clearly advertises responsibility or pride in space does two things. First, it creates a sense of “ownership” which fosters behavior that challenges abuse of that space. “Owners” that have a vested interest are more likely to report violations to authorities. Second, a sense of “my space” or “my place” creates an environment where strangers or suspicious characters stand out and are more easily identified.

Surveillance and territoriality are two major deterrents to crime. For example, many of our communities mark their territory with signage that is visible upon entry. Use of Neighborhood Watch signs has historically been another way to mark a territory and advertise the interest and concern of that community. One can further mark a territory with plant materials or fences.



1.0 Audit of Existing Conditions

Territory ultimately fosters a psychological deterrent in the perpetrator and enhances the sense of neighborhood in any environment. Fear of crime is reduced when this feeling of unity is accomplished. Simply put, a “bad guy” is likely to commit his bad deed elsewhere.

TRAIL PERIMETER

Currently many of the trail segments that pass close to or through communities, neighborhoods and business districts are not visible or easily discernible, even to those familiar with the trail system. Part of this can be attributed to a lack of signage but some is related to the layout of the trail in close proximity to other roads, access pathways and conflicting commercial interests.

The general lack of perimeter differentiation does not encourage reporting or monitoring. With no reference points or relationship to the surrounding community there is little likelihood that the “observers” will notice impending trouble.

TERRITORIAL REINFORCEMENT

There was no evidence of territorial reinforcement by the Schuylkill Heritage Area Association or the communities that border the trail system in the areas visited. It was odd that where the trailhead separated two residential properties there was no differentiation between where the property ended and the trail right-of-way began, other than some normal “driveway” indicator split-rail fencing.

It is widely observed that unclaimed or unassigned space will become the property of the criminal element. Without someone to claim a clear and present relationship with the trail and the Heritage Area and the communities through which the trail passes the trail can be anyone’s. The rule of unclaimed space applies: unclaimed space occurs when a feature is built with spaces that have no assigned purpose and no one exercises

control over them. Such space lacks environmental cues that suggest how the space is to be used or who should control it.

There were no indicators of place, location or direction found along the trail perimeter. There were many interesting sites along the trail and many historical references mentioned during the tour. A community resident even stopped to explain an old building and its relationship to other buildings and features.

Community names were not evident on or along the trail. Geographic nomenclature, as mentioned earlier, has not been applied despite the way both water and land trail users use location to determine where they are, where they are going and where they will stop for breaks.

NEIGHBORHOOD BUY-IN

To date, buy-in by community groups and neighborhood associations has been minimal and informal. Though the entire trail was not surveyed during the tour there was evidence found to indicate earlier attempts at community ties. A hand-painted sign in Port Clinton was made to identify the river landing. The Brentwood Drive trailhead, part of Thun Trail in Reading, photo 9, was built by a local company and is a good example of local buy-in. Unfortunately, these were the exception and not the rule.

There did not appear to be any formal “targeting” of local groups to insure they use and take an interest in segments of the trail. Local Scout organizations, businesses that are dependent on local trails and the river and other philanthropic clubs and societies did not seem to have a formal relationship with the trail or the Schuylkill River Heritage Association. No such relationships were being pursued according to conducted interviews.



1.0 Audit of Existing Conditions

There are disconnects between neighborhoods and trail locations among those visited. Trailhead identification markers are non-existent for the most part. Simple railings and posts, photo 16, are the most common types of markers but they say nothing about the community in which they are found. What may appear to be a private drive or walkway is in fact an entrance to a trailhead. Some of the trailheads were difficult to locate during the tour. This reflects the ever-changing areas around some of the trailheads. Without appropriate signage there is a tendency to depend upon geographic indicators of place to find trail features.

There is some neighborhood activity that is not positive. In the area of the Reading Community College pedestrian bridge there was graffiti (tagging) noting R-17 (a local gang), signs of the homeless sleeping under the bridge, the smell of fecal matter, trash, a stair railing that was in need of repair, and various other signs of misuse. It is conditions such as these that serve to discourage legitimate users from taking advantage of the trail system.

Schuylkill Area Heritage Area branding was not evident during the guided tour, so it has no visible connection with neighborhood resources.

COMMUNICATIONS

Web sites offer conflicting information about the water and land trails, such as claims and available resources. Something as simple as a spelling error ("Schuykill" river web site) might lead the visitor to question the reliability of the site in providing complete and accurate information.





1.0 Audit of Existing Conditions

EMERGENCY RESPONSE CAPABILITIES

The response time for first arriving emergency response units varies depending on the location. A coordinated response to of land-based units, boats, dive teams and helicopter (if available) responds to incidents in the Montgomery and Chester County areas of the river and trail.

There is good cooperation among agencies. The Chester and Montgomery County Fire Departments do not have written mutual/automatic aid agreements for responses along the river or trail, but do have verbal agreements. Also, these agencies work well with the Pennsylvania Fish and Game Commission.

The different jurisdictions do train together on a regular basis. Neighboring jurisdiction responders frequently have the ability to share radio frequencies during an incident.

Some public education programs have taken place. A local Cable television station completed a program on water rescue operations and dive team capabilities for local rescue agencies.